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All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

EXPRESS special

Facing backlash, Govt likely to delay higher 25% ethanol blend in petrol

Move comes on back of consumer concerns on mileage and fears of engine damage

Anil Sasi
New Delhi, July 6

AMID A raging backlash over a rapid increase in the use of ethanol in petrol from 10% to 20% in just three years, the government is likely to push back the proposed shift to a higher blend of ethanol fuel E25 comprising 75% petrol and 25% ethanol.

The government had originally planned to dispense petrol blended with 20% ethanol only by 2030. But the E20 fuel — 80% petrol and 20% ethanol

E. EXPLAINED

What is the ethanol advantage?

Ethanol has many positives including low carbon content, and lower dependence on import of fossil fuels. But a rapid increase in ethanol has triggered concerns, which the government plans to address before introducing E25.

— is now the standard petrol variant available nationwide.

While no formal date has been announced for dispensing E25 blended petrol, two government decisions over the last six weeks triggered fresh

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Convention centre, museum: Nod sought for work at Indira Point

Work to protect Great Nicobar lighthouse; won't execute prohibited activity: Official

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 6

FROM A fortified lighthouse to a convention centre and museum, the Directorate of Lighthouses and Lightships at Sri Vijaya Puram (Port Blair) has sought clearance from the Andaman and Nicobar Coastal Zone Management Authority and the Environment Ministry to undertake protection and development work at Indira

Point, India's southernmost location, on Great Nicobar Island.

Official documents reviewed by *The Indian Express* show the proposed work falls in the ecologically sensitive Island CRZ (ICRZ)-1A and ICRZ-IVA categories.

Under ICRZ-1A, no development activity is permitted except for certain specified purposes such as eco-tourism and the construction of roads and

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• Southernmost point



Shah: Centre will start cooperative life insurance firm, utility aggregator

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, July 6

UNION HOME and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah announced on Monday that the central government would soon launch a cooperative life insurance company and a utility aggregator cooperative on the lines of Bharat Taxi, India's first cooperative-based taxi service. "We are set to develop a utility aggregator cooperative on the lines of Bharat Taxi in the near future. Building on the success of the IFFCO-Tokio insurance model, we are also going to establish a cooperative life insurance company, which will significantly advance the cooperative sector in the insurance domain," Shah said at an event organised on the occasion of the fifth foundation day ceremony of the Ministry of Cooperation. Shah said that cooperatives contribute about 20 per cent of farm credit, 35 per cent of fertiliser distribution, 21 per cent of sugar production, and 35 per cent of milk production today. Shah also said that Bharat Taxi, launched on February 5 this year, would be available in every state and 500 cities in the next two years. Before the cooperation min-

istry was formed in 2021, a division of the Ministry of Agriculture handled cooperatives. Shah said the biggest controversy five years ago was about whether the new ministry would lead to central interference in the functioning of state cooperatives, because co-operation is a state subject under the Constitution. "I want to reply to them that five years have passed, and not even the Opposition-ruled states have made any complaint of interference in cooperatives by the Centre," Shah said. Cooperation had been part of the agriculture ministry since 1979. When the government established the cooperation ministry on July 6, 2021, it assigned the portfolio to Shah, who is also the Union home minister. Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh, Union Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry, and Dairying and Panchayati Raj; Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma; Krishan Pal Gurjar, Minister of State for Cooperation; and Murlidhar Mohol, Minister of State for Cooperation and Civil Aviation; and senior central and state officials were also present on the occasion.

Indira Point

roads on stilts — and, in exceptional cases, for defence, strategic purposes and public utilities, subject to detailed impact assessment. Under ICRZ-IV, several activities, including land reclamation, bunding and control of erosion, are permitted and regulated. The development comes against the backdrop of the proposed Great Nicobar Island mega infrastructure project, which involves construction of a transshipment port at Galathea Bay, a greenfield airport, a power plant and an integrated township. Indira Point is located to the south of Galathea Bay. According to the Indira Point project's ICRZ map report, prepared by Anna University, the lighthouse falls in ICRZ-

IVA, while the project site boundary and other proposed facilities, including a temporary approach bund, fall in ICRZ-IA. The development work has been proposed mainly on the grounds that the lighthouse structure needs to be safeguarded and safe access to it restored, in light of continuous erosion, wave action and shoreline changes. An Environment Impact Assessment (EIA) report by PSU WAPCOS Ltd, and a Detailed Project Report by the Department of Ocean Engineering, IIT-Madras, have been submitted as part of the official proposal. The EIA report includes a coral reef survey conducted in shallow intertidal and subtidal zones. It does not specify the

impact of the proposed project on corals, if any, or the extent of corals found near the lighthouse. The report notes that during the construction phase, activities such as transportation of materials, piling work and shoreline protection work may affect air quality, coastal water quality and marine sediments. According to a letter dated June 18, sent by the Directorate of Lighthouses and Lightships, Sri Vijaya Puram, under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, to the Andaman and Nicobar Coastal Zone Management Authority under the Union Territory administration, the proposed work will be carried out in phases. The first phase, records show, involves the construction of a peripheral piled platform around the lighthouse, a piled approach structure, a rock bund, an asphalt road, and a temporary jetty.

The second phase will include reclamation work, construction of onshore facilities, slope protection, and eco-tourism facilities such as a convention centre, cafeteria, viewing tower, cycling track, museum building and a memorial or monument structure. Directorate officials said the proposal is yet to be appraised by the Andaman and Nicobar Coastal Zone Management Authority, which has to examine it in accordance with the approved plan and forward it, with its recommendations, to the Environment Ministry. When contacted, Jayanta Chakraborty, Deputy Director, Directorate of Lighthouses and Lightships, Sri Vijaya Puram, said, "We are not going to execute any prohibited activities. Any activity proposed will be carried out after obtaining the relevant and prior clearance from the competent agency."

25% ethanol blend

concerns: one, central excise duty exemption for blended fuel (22%-30% ethanol) and two, fuel standards notified by BIS for these blends. These measures were inferred as heralding the government's intent to prepare the vehicular and fuel ecosystems for the next stage of ethanol adoption, with the specific proposal to go beyond E20 stoking concern among both car makers and motorists. But even before this, the rapid upshift or advancing of the transition to E20 by five years has left a section of consumers complaining about a perceptible drop in fuel economy. They have also expressed concerns over vehicular part damage in older cars, especially as ethanol content progressively goes up. In the backdrop of such sentiments, a meeting at the most senior levels of the government last week is learnt to have advised about the need to scientifically address some of the genuine concerns. This included an effort to ask OEMs (original equipment manufacturers) to address the consumer complaints. Officials also said some of which are inferred to be "overblown". The sources said the government reckons the need to give sufficient time for ecosystem readiness and why they must avoid pushing through the transition to the E25 fuel, especially in the context of the rushed E20 transition earlier. "There is a view (within the government) that the transition beyond E20 will need to be spaced out. That is the sense we have got from vehicle manufacturers too. The idea is to go to E25 in a calibrated, graded manner for existing vehicles," a senior government official told The Indian Express. It is, however, the transition to the E25 fuels that has players in the vehicular ecosystem worried, especially given how rushed the E10 to E20 transition was. For older vehicles and those certified for E10 petrol, this transition came about rather quickly, without sufficient warnings of the consumer-end pitfalls. The experience left motorists, especially those owning older cars and two-wheelers, feeling somewhat short-changed. Using a higher ethanol blend in petrol for engines, especially those not designed for these

blends, results in a drop in fuel economy depending on when the car was manufactured. Older vehicles fare comparatively worse in this transition. While a fuel with 10% ethanol (E10) made little difference to a car's performance, the transition to E20 did impact the operational parameters of older vehicles. And the worsening of the performance does not exactly progress in a linear fashion as the blending levels keep increasing. Ethanol has lower calorific value than petrol, which results in a perceptible drop in mileage. Also, regular petrol cars running on higher ethanol blends, alongside the drop in mileage, are harder to start on winter mornings because ethanol burns at a higher temperature than petrol. The concern that auto companies have expressed is that filling E25 fuel in internal combustion engine vehicles, especially older ones, could see some damage to parts owing to factors like corrosion, given ethanol's hygroscopic nature that promotes water uptake. Ethanol also has its positives, including a higher octane number (or the fuel's ability to withstand premature combustion due to compression). Plus, higher blending is more eco-friendly given ethanol's lower carbon content and cuts down on fuel imports. Multiple car makers in India told *The Indian Express* that they have now begun working on engines with higher compression ratios to extract the maximum mileage out of higher ethanol blends, but that is all for the future. The transition to E25 is something that vehicle owners privately admit to be concerned about, especially if this is rushed through. On its part, the government continues to maintain that the roll-out of higher ethanol-petrol blends will only be done after proper testing and stakeholder consultations. The proposed E25 transition requires automakers to do additional engineering and validation work around engine calibration, fuel-system durability, corrosion resistance, and material compatibility. And homologation — the process that officially certifies a vehicle or component as compliant with regulations pertaining to safety, environment, and road-worthiness — at the end. All this needs time, which could be impacted if the transition is a rushed affair.

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EXPRESSexclusive

Govt planning major administrative rejig

Officers working in ‘comfort zones’ for over five years to be in focus

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 6

THE DELHI government is planning a major administrative reshuffle with around 60-70% of cadre and ex-cadre officials — including DANICS (Delhi, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Lakshadweep, Daman and Diu, and Dadra and Nagar Haveli (Civil) Service) officers, ad-hoc DANICS officers, Sub-Divisional Magistrates (SDMs) and other Grade-I officers — likely to be transferred, said sources. These officials and staffers “have been working in a ‘comfort zone’ for over five

years” in their departments, sources added. According to sources, the latest move — which is being executed weeks after the Capital saw a major bureaucratic rejig — comes in the wake of the directions from Chief Minister Rekha Gupta to bring transparency and curb corruption. “The process has already been started and transfers are taking place. The CM strictly ordered that there is no place for corruption, laxity, or negligence at any level of governance...,” said a senior official. The officers may be transferred within or outside their respective departments. Recently, the government conducted a major reshuffle in the Finance and Accounts department where 52 officers, who had been serving at the same place for five years or more, were transferred with immediate effect. These included 23 Deputy Controllers of



The move follows directions from Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. EXPRESS

Accounts and 29 Senior Accounts Officers. In addition, 19 Senior Accounts Officers were promoted as Deputy Controllers of Accounts, expanding their responsibilities in recognition of their performance. “Following the CM’s directions, the transfers and postings have been made purely on the basis of administrative requirements and with the objective of promoting integrity

and transparency in the system. To make the administration more efficient, the government has assigned new responsibilities to 23 Deputy Controllers of Accounts and 29 Senior Accounts Officers,” said an official. Besides, the CM has also been seen actively keeping an eye on the functioning of bureaucracy and administrative level officials. A few months ago in April, she also carried out a surprise inspection at the Trade and Taxes department at ITO. After finding that several senior level officials were not present in their desks, she ordered for strict implementation of the biometric attendance system for all the officials, including additional chief secretaries and secretary level officials. Show-cause notices were also issued to several officials who were found absent. The department later transferred a

total of 162 officers and employees, including three Assistant Commissioners, especially those who had remained posted at the same location for more than three years. The reshuffle included 58 Grade-I Section Officers, 22 Grade-II Assistant Section Officers, 74 Grade-III Senior Assistants and 5 Grade-IV Junior Assistants. Apart from this, Gupta recently had also recommended to Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu to transfer 39 doctors posted in Tihar and Mandoli jails for over five years. The list included both specialist doctors and General Duty Medical Officers (GDMOs). Officials said that several of these doctors have remained posted at the same location since 2014, with their tenure exceeding 11 years. The proposal also included the deployment of around 35 other doctors in their place. In total, approxi-

mately 74 transfers have been proposed. Sources said that directions have also been given to departments concerned for making a list of officials posted in the same position for a longer period. “Some staffers are posted in the same post because of health reasons or any important project but the reshuffling has to be done in every three years especially those posted in finance and accounts dealing sections...more such transfers are expected in the coming months,” the official underlined. Last month, the Delhi government transferred over 50 IAS and DANICS officers, including secretaries of four ministers and secretary-level officials in the Health Department. Sources said the transfers came following alleged irregularities in the procurement of medical equipment.

‘Internal combustion engine has reached its technological limit... (But) transition to electric must go hand in hand with cleaner power sources’



EXPERT EXPLAINS
GAUHAR RAZA

Why is the transition to electric vehicles important?

Because the internal combustion engine (ICE) has more or less reached its technological limits. For decades, engineers have tried to improve its efficiency. There have certainly been improvements, but most of them have come through better accessories, electronics, design, and supporting systems rather than dramatic gains in the engine itself. That is why research and innovation are increasingly focused on electric mobility. This is where the next technological leap is expected. The future of transportation is moving in that direction.

You say ICE technology has reached the limits of its efficiency. Can you explain?

The overall efficiency of a vehicle is determined by the combined efficiency of its components, not by the maximum efficiency of any single part. In an internal combustion engine, energy is lost at several stages — through heat, friction and the various mechanical systems that transfer power from the engine to the wheels. Even if individual components are improved, overall efficiency has a practical ceiling. That is why, despite decades of research, there has been only limited scope to

significantly improve the efficiency of ICE vehicles.

Are EVs the last word in environmental terms?

EVs certainly reduce pollution within cities because there are no tailpipe emissions. But we must look at the entire energy chain.

If the electricity used to charge these vehicles comes from thermal power plants, then a part of the environmental burden is shifted from cities to the places where electricity is generated. So, while EVs improve urban air quality, their overall environmental benefit depends on how clean the electricity grid is. The transition to electric mobility should go hand in hand with cleaner sources of power generation.

From an engineering perspective, how are EVs different from conventional vehicles?

One important difference is regenerative braking. In a conventional vehicle, much of the energy is lost as heat when you apply the brakes. In an electric vehicle, part of that energy can be recovered and sent back to the battery. That means driving behaviour becomes much more important. Smooth acceleration, anticipating traffic conditions, and avoiding unnecessary braking all help improve efficiency. The vehicle rewards efficient driving.

Why is the range of an EV such an important part of the conversation around electric mobility?

The battery can run the

motor only for a limited time as it stores a finite amount of energy. Its capacity is measured in ampere-hours, and the amount of energy it delivers depends on the electrical load placed on it. The greater the load on the battery the faster its stored energy is consumed. Rapid acceleration, repeated braking, and aggressive driving all increase the load on the battery, reducing the distance the vehicle can travel on a single charge.

E. The range of an EV is determined not only by the battery’s rated capacity but also by how efficiently stored energy is used. Manufacturers usually specify a certified range under standard testing conditions. In real-world conditions, the range depends on how the vehicle is driven. If driven smoothly under favourable conditions, the vehicle may even exceed its certified range.

What are the biggest challenges that remain before EVs can become mainstream?

One is the availability of charging infrastructure. Another is ensuring that electricity increasingly comes from cleaner sources. What also needs attention is what happens to batteries after they reach the end of their life. We need effective systems for their reuse, recycling, and safe disposal. As EV adoption grows, battery life-

cycle management will become increasingly important.

Do you see hydrogen as an alternative to battery electric vehicles?

Hydrogen is a promising technology, and research is continuing in that area. But it is still very expensive. Producing hydrogen, storing it, transporting it and building the infrastructure required to use it involve high costs. We know when Hydrogen and Oxygen are mixed, they form water (H₂O). The same reaction is used for charging a ‘bank of cells’ which drives an electric motor. Oxygen is in plenty in the atmosphere, but Hydrogen as fuel is way more expensive compared to traditional fuel or even electricity. Therefore, for the proliferation of this technology, either we have to wait for a major technological breakthrough or a situation where we run out of options.

Hydrogen may play an important role in the future, particularly for certain applications, but at the moment, it cannot replace battery-electric vehicles on a large scale. Only large buses and heavy transport vehicles fuelled by Hydrogen come close to a viable option.

Gauhar Raza is a science communicator and a former Chief Scientist with the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR). He spoke with Sophiya Mathew.

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2 engineering interventions at heart of Gurgaon's plan to tackle waterlogging along key corridor

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, July 6

CROSS-CONNECTIONS between surface and stormwater drains, and new water chutes: these are the two key engineering interventions introduced by the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA) to prevent waterlogging along the Hero Honda Chowk-Umang Bhardwaj Chowk as the Millennium City takes a series of steps to tackle the perennial issue of waterlogging this monsoon season.

The corridor between the two intersections is among Gurgaon's key arterial routes for residents and daily commuters and a lifeline for commercial transit.

Located along the Delhi-Jaipur Expressway (NH-48), Hero

Honda Chowk — that sees heavy vehicular movement — is a major hub for office spaces. It is flanked by the Info Technology Park and houses significant manufacturing bases, including the Hero MotoCorp facility in Sector 33. The intersection also anchors the city's civic administration, with the Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG) headquarters situated nearby in Sector 34.

Further down the corridor, Umang Bhardwaj Chowk serves as the link connecting the Dwarka Expressway to Delhi-Jaipur Expressway and East Gurgaon.

For thousands of residents in the developing real estate clusters between Sectors 81 and 95, this chowk is the main transit point into the city's residential parts and business hubs. Addi-

tionally, it funnels a substantial volume of traffic entering the city from Pataudi and Rewari.

Because of this high convergence of local, industrial, and inter-city traffic, any waterlogging on this brief corridor leads to severe bottlenecks. When the road floods, it cripples movement across West Gurgaon and leads to traffic snarls that spill over onto the national highway.

To accelerate the discharge of rainwater from the main carriageway, the GMDA has constructed three cross-drain connections along the Sector 10A/37-2 master sector dividing road. Officials said the 600-mm diameter pipelines have been laid to link the surface drains directly with the master stormwater drain. "Coupled with this, new water chutes, or road gullies, have been constructed

at strategic locations along the corridor. These chutes are designed to channel rainwater rapidly from the road surface into the surface drains, which will then empty directly into the master drainage network through the new cross-connections," a GMDA spokesperson said.

These interventions are key to addressing a long-standing infrastructural bottleneck in the city. According to officials, drainage capacity in several areas is severely compromised due to illegal overlaps made by residents between the sewage and stormwater drainage networks. By creating direct cross-drain connections and dedicated road chutes along this high-traffic corridor, the GMDA aims to bypass these compromised networks.

GROUND report

'No child has been missed, right?': Campaign launched after polio virus is found in Ghaziabad sewage

Drishti Jain
Ghaziabad, July 6

AT 11 ON a Thursday morning, Rajkumari balances a blue vaccine cold box in one hand and a pink file in the other as she knocks on an iron gate in Vijay Nagar, a densely packed neighbourhood in Ghaziabad.

A little girl leans out from a second-floor window. "Is there a small child in the house?" Rajkumari calls. Moments later, a young mother emerges carrying her five-month-old daughter.

Rajkumari asks the baby's name, age and father's name, recording each answer in her register. Beside her, an ASHA worker gently tilts the infant's head back. Two drops of polio vaccine land on her tongue. The baby bursts into tears. Before leaving, Rajkumari

pauses. "No child has been missed, right?" she asks. "Tell me honestly."

The team moves on. The urgency behind Rajkumari's rounds lies in a sewage sample collected from Vijay Nagar on June 5. It tested positive for vaccine-derived poliovirus, a rare strain that can circulate in communities where immunisation coverage is low.

India was declared free of wild poliovirus in 2014 after decades of mass immunisation. But environmental surveillance — testing sewage for traces of the virus — continues as an early warning system. After the detection in Ghaziabad, officials traced the sewage network, identified 12 neighbourhoods with about 150,000 residents as high-risk areas, and intensified vaccination efforts under the

watch of the National Centre for Disease Control and the World Health Organization.

Rajkumari is one of hundreds of health workers now working under this intensified campaign, going door to door to ensure no child under five is missed.

They weave through narrow lanes lined with closely packed houses. Some doors stay shut despite repeated knocks. Others are locked, their occupants away at work. Each missed house is marked in Rajkumari's register for another visit.

A few hundred metres away, Vijay Nagar's concrete homes give way to a cluster of tin-roofed shelters beneath an under-construction apartment tower. Families from Bihar and nearby districts of Uttar Pradesh have made homes here, many of



At each house, health workers urge families to tell them if they have a child under 5 years so they can be vaccinated. AMIT MEHRA

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the men working at construction sites while the women care for children or work as domestic helpers.

Stepping past piles of garbage and algae-covered drains, Rajkumari and Manisha stop at every shack.

"Is there a child under five?" When Shyam, a 32-year-old



carpenter from Darbhanga, sees the health workers, he calls out to his young son before the boy runs off between the rows of homes.

"Isko bhi pila do (Give him the drops too)," he says.

Shyam says vaccination campaigns were a familiar part of life in his village.

Every household gets the same question more than once. If someone says there are no children inside, Rajkumari asks again before moving on.

After the sewage detection, officials say they strengthened supervision, redrew vaccination maps and instructed teams to revisit locked homes until every eligible child had been reached.

"We reviewed every area covered in the last round to make sure nothing had been missed," says Dr Soniya Patel, the medical officer in charge overseeing the campaign. "We cannot miss any child."

But reluctance is not confined to the city's poorest neighbourhoods. Amit Pal, 22, another vaccination worker, says some parents refuse to open their doors or insist there are no young children inside. If

persuasion fails, supervisors return to counsel the family.

"We cannot leave any child," he says.

Across the road, in the gated towers of Paramount Symphony, the conversations are different, but the hesitation can be much the same.

Auxiliary Nurse Midwife Usha Yadav recently spent 45 minutes persuading a mother to allow her child to receive the vaccine. Only after showing news reports on her phone about the virus detected in Ghaziabad's sewage did the woman agree. "Only then did she agree," Yadav says.

By 1 pm, Rajkumari returns to the Ayushman Arogya Mandir after five hours on foot. "Some families were away. We will visit again over the next few days," she says.

PRIME MINISTER BEGINS THREE-NATION TOUR

Defence, critical minerals on table at India-Indonesia meeting today

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 6

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Monday began a three-nation tour of Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand. He said the visit, from July 6-11, “will further strengthen India’s Act East Policy, MAHASAGAR Vision as well as our outlook towards a free and open Indo-Pacific”.

Modi, who reached Jakarta Monday afternoon, was received at the airport by Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto. The two leaders are expected to focus on bilateral cooperation in defence and maritime partnerships, critical minerals, food security and digital economy at their meeting on Tuesday.

“I’m touched by President Prabowo Subianto’s gesture of welcoming me at the airport,” Modi said on X. “In 2018, we elevated our relations to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, which has benefited our people. During this visit, President Prabowo Subianto and I will hold discussions aimed at adding even more momentum to this partnership across diverse sectors,” he said.

While this is his fourth visit to Indonesia, it is the first bilateral visit since the elevation of ties to



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Indonesia President Prabowo Subianto after arriving in Jakarta on Monday. ANI

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a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in May 2018. “President Prabowo and I will visit the Prambanan Temple complex at Yogyakarta. This will ensure closer cultural linkages between our nations,” Modi said on X.

Sources said India’s defence and security cooperation with Indonesia has seen increased

momentum and expanding scope through high-level visits, regular bilateral and multilateral exercises, and deeper defence industry cooperation, including the sale of BrahMos missiles.

As maritime neighbours, both countries adopted the Shared Vision of India-Indonesia Maritime Cooperation in the

E. EXPLAINED

Strong trade ties

Indonesia has emerged as India’s second largest trading partner in ASEAN region with bilateral trade of US\$ 24.78 billion in 2025-26. Over 130 Indian companies are invested in different sectors in Indonesia.

Indo-Pacific in 2018. “The stationing of an Indonesian liaison officer at IFC-IOR (Information Fusion Centre - Indian Ocean Region) will give further impetus to our maritime domain awareness. India will also be earmarking slots for Indonesian cadets and officers at the National Defence Academy and Defence Services Staff College which will enhance defence capacity building,” sources said.

On cooperation in critical minerals, officials said Indonesia dominates the sector, commanding roughly 21% of world’s nickel reserves and ranking among the top global producers of copper, bauxite and tin. On trade and investments, officials said there are “strong synergies

between developmental visions of Viksit Bharat 2047 and Emas (Golden) Indonesia 2045”.

The two sides will also work towards building resilient food security cooperation. Officials said several Indonesian delegations have visited India to learn from social welfare schemes like the PDS, fortified rice scheme and fertiliser subsidy reforms. Indonesia’s free nutritious meals initiative is modelled on India’s midday meal programme.

According to officials, India is set to commemorate the centenary of Rabindranath Tagore’s visit to Indonesia in 2027.

From Indonesia, Modi will travel to Australia. “My visit will strengthen our Comprehensive Strategic Partnership and I shall, in my discussions with PM (Anthony) Albanese, take forward our relations in areas of defence and security, trade and investments, education and mobility, and people-to-people ties,” Modi said on X. On his New Zealand tour he said on X, “I shall discuss with PM (Christopher) Luxon how to further enhance economic, trade and commercial engagements. India and New Zealand have committed themselves to strengthening bilateral trade and commercial ties with the signing of the FTA.”

NIA names Hafiz Saeed as accused in Pahalgam attack chargesheet

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 6

THE NATIONAL Investigation Agency (NIA) has named Lashkar-e-Taiba founder Hafiz Saeed as an accused in its supplementary chargesheet on the Pahalgam terror attack.

“On Sunday, the chargesheet was filed before the NIA Special Court in Jammu. Hafiz Saeed has been charged in his individual capacity and as the chief of the banned LeT and its proxy, The Resistance Front,” an NIA spokesperson said.

The NIA has charged Saeed under various sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), invoking, among others, sections related to waging war against India and hatching a conspiracy from across the border.

A dossier on Saeed, attached with the chargesheet,

details his involvement in various other terror attacks in India — the Red Fort attack in 2000 in which three persons, including two soldiers, were killed; the attack on a CRPF camp in Ramapur in 2008 in which seven security personnel and one civilian were killed; the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks in 2008 in which 166 people, including foreign nationals, were killed; and the attack on a BSF convoy in Udhampur in 2015 in which two security personnel were killed.

“Hafiz Saeed is accused in various cases registered and being investigated by the NIA, which inter alia include Jammu and Kashmir terror conspiracy and terror funding case and Dukhtaran-e-Millat case, and chargesheet had been filed against him in the 26/11 Mumbai terror attack. A Red Corner Notice was issued against him on August 28, 2009,



Hafiz Saeed is the chief of the banned LeT and its proxy TRF

for his role in the 26/11 Mumbai terror attack case and he was designated as a global terrorist by the United Nations under the United Nations Security Council Resolution, 1267, on December 10, 2008,” says the dossier.

In India, Saeed was designated as a terrorist on September 4, 2019. Last week, his son-law, Hafiz Khalid Waleed, was also designated as a terrorist. Waleed, the mastermind behind

the June 2016 Pampore attack in which eight CRPF personnel were killed, was designated as a global terrorist by the US Department of the Treasury in August 2012.

The latest chargesheet, filed in continuation of the original 1,597-page chargesheet on the Pahalgam attack, provides details of Pakistan’s conspiracy, Hafiz Saeed’s role, and supporting evidence collected by NIA in the case through scientific investigation and on-ground examination.

Twenty-six people were killed in the attack in Pahalgam on April 22, 2025.

“Chargesheeting Hafiz Saeed will enhance the capacity of security and law enforcement agencies to initiate coordinated legal, investigative and preventive actions against him at both the national and international levels,” a source said.

In its earlier chargesheet

filed on December 15 last year, the NIA had named Pakistani “handler” Sajid Jatt, three terrorists who were killed by security forces in July 2025 — Faisal Jatt alias Suleman, Habeeb Tahir alias Jibran, and Hamza Afghani -- and two arrested accused, Kashmir residents Parvaiz Ahmad and Bashir Ahmad Jothar. It had also named the LeT/ TRF as accused.

“NIA continues to probe the case to unravel the complete conspiracy by Pakistan, which has been actively sponsoring terrorism on Indian soil from across the border,” the NIA spokesperson said.

The NIA chargesheet has relied on, among other things, two Android phones found at the site of the encounter in which the three terrorists were killed in July 2025, sources said, adding that the probe agency has confirmed the devices were bought in Pakistan.

ZEE5 removes ‘Satluj’ after govt cites security, IT Rules; SGPC and SAD slam move

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Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 6

OTT PLATFORM ZEE5 has removed actor-singer Diljit Dosanjh-starrer film ‘Satluj’ after receiving a notice from the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (MIB), citing security issues and obligations under the IT Rules 2021, it is learnt. The film, which was stuck with the Central Board of Film Certification for more than three years, was released uncut on ZEE5 on Friday and removed on Sunday evening.

The development gave way to a furious debate with political parties and the SGPC pushing for the release of the film and the actor-singer saying that he “had a feeling that something like this would happen”.

The film is based on the life of Punjab-based human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khaira, who disappeared in 1995. In 2005, four Punjab Police personnel were convicted for his abduction and murder and sentenced to seven years in prison. Two years later, the Punjab and Haryana High Court enhanced their sentence to life imprisonment.

OTT content is not regulated by the CBFC, but covered under the provisions of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021.

Officials said the makers of ‘Satluj’ had applied for CBFC certification in 2022 under a different title, ‘Punjab 95’. However, the makers did not comply with the 127 cuts and title change as suggested by the CBFC. The makers challenged

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>



Jaswant Singh Khaira biopic ‘Satluj’, starring Diljit Dosanjh. ZEE5 Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

the CBFC objections in the Bombay High Court, but later the plea was withdrawn.

The original title of the Honey Trehan-directed film was changed for release on ZEE5 without any other modification, an official said. Once the matter came to the government’s notice, it asked ZEE5 to take down the film due to “security” concerns.

Subsequently, on Sunday evening, just two days after its release, ZEE5 informed viewers that the film was no longer available in India.

A code of ethics, part of the IT Rules, requires OTT platforms to avoid publishing content prohibited by law and to undertake age-based classification of content.

The Bombay High Court placed an interim pan-India stay on Rules 9(1) and 9(3) of the IT Rules 2021, which required digital news media and online publishers to adhere to a “code of ethics” and a three-tier grievance redressal mechanism.

The code of ethics also states that when deciding “to feature or transmit or publish or exhibit” any content, a publisher shall exercise due caution and discretion when it affects the sovereignty and integrity of India or threatens, endangers or jeopardises the security of

the state.

It states that caution should also be exercised in case the content is detrimental to India’s friendly relations with foreign countries or is likely to incite violence or disturb the maintenance of public order.

Meanwhile, Kulwant Singh Manan, chief secretary of the SGPC said: “The government should ensure that people see this film. What is wrong if reality is shown and public comes to know of what happened during those days in Punjab.”

SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal said, “This is not mere censorship; it is an assault on our collective memory, truth, and freedom of expression...”

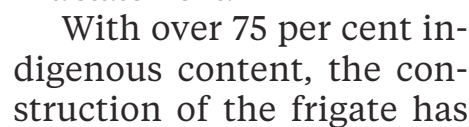
In an expansive session on Instagram Live from the US where he is on tour, Diljit expressed his anguish. “I had a feeling on Friday that something like this will happen. This was already on my mind. It is not something to be shocked about (the ban) ... But I am satisfied that people have seen the film; it has reached them,” Dosanjh said in Punjabi.

In an Instagram post, ZEE5 said: “We are doing our bit to bring ‘Satluj’ back. Please do yours — don’t support piracy. We remain committed to exploring every possible avenue to bring ‘Satluj’ back to you.”

— WITH PTI

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 6

The warship incorporates advanced stealth features, enhanced survivability, a reduced radar signature, and a high degree of automation. The frigate is powered by a modern combined diesel or gas propulsion system, enabling high-speed operations with exceptional endurance across the full spectrum of maritime missions.



"As successive frigates of the class join the fleet, they continue to strengthen the Indian Navy's combat capability while reinforcing India's position as a

Free Whatsapp Channel [https://w](https://www.whatsapp.com/channel/0029va8t67l3v3m3w3m3w3m3)

Stealth frigate is equipped with an advanced suite of indigenous and state-of-the-art weapons and sensors, including surface-to-surface and surface-to-air missile systems, electronic warfare capabilities, comprehensive anti-submarine warfare systems, and an integrated combat management system.

leading indigenous warship-building nation," the Navy said, adding that Mahendragiri will serve as a formidable force multiplier, safeguarding the nation's maritime interests and contributing to a secure, stable, [atsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VR](https://www.atsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VR)

Last month, the fifth Project 17A stealth frigate, INS Dunagiri, was commissioned into the Navy. Earlier this year, in April, the fourth frigate, INS Taragiri, was commissioned. In August last year, the Navy commissioned the second and third Project 17A frigates, INS Udayagiri and INS Himgiri. The lead ship of the class, INS Nilgiri, was commissioned in January 2025. The seventh and final Project 17A frigate is also expected to be commissioned later this year.



How to absorb rain: What cities must learn

FOR MUMBAIKARS, there's a grim familiarity to the crisis unfolding in the city that has taken at least seven lives in the past five days. Relentless rain has submerged roads, inundated homes in low-lying neighbourhoods, delayed commuters, and forced educational institutes to suspend classes and examinations. The India Meteorological Department has warned of more rain over the next three days, raising fears of further flooding in the country's financial capital.

Built on what were once seven islands, much of Mumbai is land reclaimed from the sea. Large parts of the metropolis lie only a few metres above sea level. Urban expansion has disrupted the city's intricate hydrological network — creeks, salt pans and wetlands that used to absorb the rain before gradually releasing it into the sea. During every spell of intense rainfall, water tries to flow along the erstwhile water channels — that explains the regular inundation of areas like Hindmata, Kurla, Sion and parts of the western suburbs. After the devastating floods of 2005, the city's administrators did initiate meaningful changes — pumping stations were installed, and forecasting systems strengthened. However, despite being revamped on large stretches, Mumbai's drainage network is ill-equipped to deal with short but intense bursts of rainfall. The storm-water system relies on gravity to empty water into the sea. This mechanism comes apart when heavy downpour coincides with high tide, like in the past few days — the seawater rises above the drainage outfall and pushes it back.

The predicaments of Mumbai's administrators are similar to those of their counterparts in several parts of the world — it's increasingly becoming apparent that improving drainage systems alone does not offer security against climate vagaries. China's Sponge City policy, adopted after the Beijing floods of 2012, tries to address this challenge by enhancing the water retention capacity of the country's urban centres — replacing concrete pavements with permeable ones, restoring urban wetlands and creating artificial lakes to store rainwater. Planners in the Netherlands' low-lying cities have also been innovative. Instead of only strengthening traditional flood defences, they have created everyday amenities like water squares — these collect water during episodes of extreme rain, while doubling as recreation centres during the dry season — and incentivised the construction of green roofs. Mumbai's municipal agency, too, has lake restoration projects on its agenda. However, "blue-green infrastructure" remains largely a niche concept in most parts of India, including in its financial capital. The country's urban centres need housing, transport, commercial districts and modern infrastructure. The task for planners and administrators is to design them in a manner that does not render cities defenceless against extreme weather.

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi is travelling to Jakarta, Auckland and Melbourne, undertaking a sequence of visits that may define New Delhi's approach to the Indo-Pacific in the coming decades. A bold and audacious redrawing of the map of this vast maritime region is underway. This effort will seek to recover autonomy for the powers that reside here, and it will recentre the region's story on good growth and inclusive development, away from the whims of extractive super-power contestation. India envisions a new geometry of collaboration, one not dependent on axioms outlined in Washington or Beijing, but drawn up by those who live here and thus have the most to gain or lose.

The first stop, and the lynchpin of any plan for the Indo-Pacific, is Indonesia. The world's third-most populous nation is the archetypal Indo-Pacific power. Indeed, it is the nation the term might almost have been coined to describe. The archipelago sits astride every crucial trade route between the two oceans, has abundant natural resources and, like India, is a civilisational state that has long been committed to a "free and active" foreign policy that secures its autonomy.

It is the relationship between India and Indonesia that will set the course for the broader maritime region. And what is often overlooked is that this partnership has already grown manifold. Objectively, Jakarta

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029VaN2VRb6RGJOKH6oBdF>

is one of New Delhi's most important partners. If you look at goods alone, trade between the two nations, at just under \$30 billion a year, is significant. It has overtaken trade between India and the United Kingdom, and runs neck and neck with Indo-German trade. Goods trade will only grow, stimulated by the upgradation of India's free trade agreement with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), and so will services, under-represented and under-reported at present. With a focus on marine logistics, technology and financial services, and new supply chains, this partnership will form the foundation for a free and open trading architecture in the region.

And it will be necessary, as well, for Prime Minister Modi and President Prabowo Subianto to move the relationship forward if the Indo-Pacific is to create a genuinely indigenous and independent security framework. These two maritime powers are the only ones with the scale, capacity and presence required to manage the region's most vital chokepoints. Together they are the only powers positioned to become net security providers of this ocean, not by invitation from Washington or deference to Beijing, but because the sea lanes are theirs to protect in the first place.

Australia, meanwhile, is India's breakout partner. A new economic partnership, Australia-India Econ-



SAMIR SARAN

It will be necessary, as well, for Prime Minister Modi and President Prabowo Subianto to move the relationship forward if the Indo-Pacific is to create a genuinely indigenous and independent security framework

omic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA), was negotiated in 2022, signalling New Delhi's new vision for trade. But it also built trust, a far scarcer commodity. That trust can serve to underpin the next stage of this relationship. That would require deeper integration: Our financial services, nuclear energy and resource processing industries must be integrated. These are areas where we both have great abilities, and our search is for autonomy, scale, and new technology. The strategic objective, once the habit of cooperation settles, must be defence co-production, where both could serve as trusted enablers of broader regional and global security.

New Zealand is a crucial key to the puzzle and not only because of its own strengths. The innovation island hosts advanced manufacturing capabilities, space and deep technology enterprises and agri-processing innovation, making it a vital component of India's innovation sectors, food-security imperative and farm-income strategy. With the fourth largest exclusive economic zone (EEZ), the blue economy in its entirety is a natural domain of partnership with Aotearoa.

Alongside Canberra, Wellington will provide another crucial bridge to the Five Eyes security-intelligence ecosystem. This adds further resilience to a still new relationship.

Finally, together, India and the Australian and New Zealand Army Corps (ANZAC) can become the delivery mechanism for development across the South Pacific and neighbouring parts of ASEAN. They will provide the financing, digital and physical infrastructure, and human capital the region badly needs, as well as a credible alternative to exploitative or unreliable partners. India is, after all, the largest theatre for discovering development solutions for the planet; once that innovative energy is paired with the capital and standing in the Pacific of the ANZAC nations, it offers a development pathway that does not force smaller nations to be burdened with perverse debt or lease a naval base to supposed benefactors.

Modi's new arc of trust will hold the Indo-Pacific together in these disruptive times. With India at its centre, draw the arc east from India through Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand. Then draw it west through the United Arab Emirates and the Gulf and down the eastern seaboard of Africa.

This is the real story of the upcoming tour: The geographical centre of the Indo-Pacific resetting and redrawing an emerging order so that those who share this oceanic domain write the rules instead of just inheriting them.

The writer is president, Observer Research Foundation

NATO's challenge: Spending on collective defence



AJAI SHUKLA

WITH EASTERN Europe and West Asia in prolonged turmoil, leaders of NATO's 32 member countries are gathered in Turkey for the Ankara Summit. The cornerstone of the world's most powerful alliance, enshrined in Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty, stipulates that an armed attack against one or more of its members will be considered an attack against all. But now, alongside the military threat from its principal adversary, Russia, NATO faces demands for more equitable burden-sharing from its principal financial contributor, the US.

Last fortnight, NATO outlined the broad themes expected to dominate discussions during the Ankara Summit. The first is a topic that has been contentious ever since NATO's beginnings: Spending levels on defence by the alliance's European members.

At last year's summit in The Hague, the European members committed to investing 5 per cent of GDP in defence. This covers two categories. Each member must spend at least 3.5 per cent of GDP on core defence equipment and to meet NATO capability targets. In addition, NATO countries must spend 1.5 per cent of GDP on defence- and security-related investments, such as protection of critical infrastructure, defence networks, and strengthening the defence industrial base.

The focus of the summit will be on delivering on the 5 per cent pledge with the US piling pressure on the European allies to step up. Washington is altering its contribution to NATO, pressing Europe to grow high-end capabilities such as logistics, command and control, aerial refuelling, missile defence, and special operations forces.

NATO watchers expect three themes to dominate the summit. The first will be a continued focus on "alliance adaptation", as NATO seeks to transform from a force optimised for crisis management to one focussed on collective defence against peer competitors. The second will be "capability delivery", with NATO identifying its security requirements and actually fielding those capabilities at the speed demanded by today's security environment. The third will be "technology and industrial resilience".

The rocky path to NATO's current 5 per cent commitment dates back to its founding in 1949. For its first 40 years, NATO formed the first line of western European defence against the threat of invasion by the

Soviet-led Warsaw Pact. During the 1950s, NATO's European allies willingly spent an average of 4.8 per cent of their GDP on defence. Alongside this, the US heavily subsidised NATO, picking up 60-76 per cent of the tab for Europe's defence.

With the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, NATO countries sharply pared defence spending to fund public infrastructure and social programmes. In 2006, at the Riga Summit, NATO's defence ministers issued a guideline advising member countries to spend at least 2 per cent of their GDP on defence. But, with the Soviet threat having receded, the non-binding Riga commitment was largely ignored.

Russia's annexation of Ukraine's Crimean peninsula in 2014 was the wake-up call that goaded NATO into reversing a quarter century of spending cuts. At the 2014 Wales Summit, the allies signed the Defence Investment Pledge, committing themselves to a spending target of 2 per cent of GDP by 2024.

Even so, it took a full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022 to push NATO countries into adopting the new target of 5 per cent of GDP by 2035. Galvanised by the Russian threat, 2023 saw an unprecedented 11 per cent increase in NATO's real defence spending. In 2024, the European allies spent a combined total of \$380 billion. In 2025, collective defence spending rose by another \$90 billion. Some NATO allies are on track to reach the 5 per cent target in 2026, far ahead of schedule.

European security experts say the success of the Ankara Summit will rest not just on pushing NATO allies into spending more, but on directing spending into the right capabilities. NATO increasingly believes that Ukraine, which has demonstrated astounding capabilities in battlefield adaptation and innovation, provides the right blueprint for a more effective way to operate in a war fuelled by AI. Kyiv has demonstrated how to sense the domain, adapt cheap commercial tools, and iterate fast.

Ultimately, military advantage will be generated less by platforms and weapons and more by the ability to innovate, to produce, to sustain and to adapt faster than the adversary. Developing an agile defence industry will be the centrepiece of the Ankara Summit, with the entire day of July 7 being an industry forum.

The writer is a retired Army officer and journalist

Don't scrap WhatsApp username, address the harms



SRINATH SRIDHARAN



ANAND VENKATANARAYAN

THE GOVERNMENT of India's reported decision to seek an explanation from Meta over WhatsApp's proposed username feature is about far more than a messaging application. Should governments regulate digital technologies by focussing on the harms they create, or by scrutinising individual product features before they reach citizens? True, India is witnessing an unprecedented rise in cyber fraud, identity theft and so-called digital arrest scams. Yet good intentions do not automatically translate into good regulation. Every regulatory intervention must ultimately be judged by a simple question: Does it solve the problem it seeks to address?

Governments should regulate digital harms, not individual software features whose risks can already be addressed through existing law and better product safeguards. Regulating software architecture risks converting governments into arbiters of product design, an approach that no serious digital economy can sustain. A WhatsApp username replaces the visible mobile number during user interactions. Every account remains linked to an underlying number obtained through verification. Platforms retain account identifiers and records. What does change is something equally important to citizens. Millions of Indians routinely disclose their personal numbers to strangers because digital communication leaves them with no alternative. Ironically, the proposed feature advances another public policy objective that India itself has increasingly embraced over the past decade: Better protection of personal information.

If official concerns remain, regulators can require platforms to adopt privacy-preserving defaults. Users could receive messages from username-based accounts only after explicit consent, much as spam filters transformed email without questioning the legitimacy of email itself. Email has arguably become one of the world's most important pieces of digital public infrastructure. Every email address is, in essence, a username. Had governments attempted to regulate email by questioning username-based identities themselves, one of the internet's foundational technologies might never have evolved into the trusted communication infrastructure upon which governments, businesses and citizens now depend every day. The possibility of impersonation is therefore neither new nor unique to WhatsApp. Fraudsters already impersonate public officials over telephone calls, banks through SMS messages, government agencies through counterfeit websites, businesses through spoofed email addresses and public figures across social media platforms.

A proportionate response would focus on platform responsibility rather than platform architecture. Platforms can disable unsolicited messages from unknown username-only accounts by default, provide enhanced verification for public institutions and prominent individuals, and, among other measures, deploy AI to detect deceptive usernames. India requires a more technologically informed philosophy of digital policymaking. Digital sovereignty is a legitimate national objective. It is too important to become an omnibus justification for scrutinising every technological evolution. If India wishes to lead the AI century rather than merely participate in it, its regulatory institutions must display the confidence to regulate principles over products, harms over hypotheticals, and outcomes over architecture.

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Sridharan is a corporate advisor and author of Family and Dhanda, and Venkatanarayanan is a digital policy researcher

It took a full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022 to push NATO countries into adopting the new target of 5 per cent of GDP by 2035

The Ideas Page

TUESDAY, JULY 7, 2026



R S SHARMA
AND SWETHA RAVI KUMAR

India Energy Stack could power next-gen enterprise

WHEN PRIME Minister Narendra Modi chaired a meeting of the Economic Advisory Council a few weeks ago, the discussion ranged across fiscal management, ease of doing business, and the reforms required to keep investments flowing. One structural theme connects all of these: Energy.

Energy is more than one sector among many; it is the input cost of the entire economy. Industry is the single largest consumer of electricity. Yet it pays among the highest power tariffs in Asia. For many millions, energy also remains a matter of basic access.

The power sector's transformation in the last decade has been far-reaching. India operates one of the world's largest synchronous grids at a single national frequency. We have moved from chronic shortages to broad supply adequacy. NASA's imagery of artificial light at night has shown India's remarkable progress in making energy accessible to all in the last decade. We are also among the largest producers of renewable energy. We reached 50 per cent of installed capacity from non-fossil sources in 2025 and are now working towards 500 GW of non-fossil power by 2030.

Over the past decade, India has closed longstanding gaps in physical infrastructure, lowering the transaction costs of economic activity. The next substantial gains lie

in digitalising how these systems operate.

The task now is to ensure that the data these systems generate can move securely across institutional boundaries, so this investment delivers its full value. This shift, from building physical assets to drawing value from them through digitalisation, reflects a broader pattern in India's development. Having built cross-sectoral digital public infrastructure in Aadhaar and UPI, India is now developing domain-specific platforms in health, agriculture, logistics, and recently, energy. These share a common design. Aadhaar, UPI, and other digital public infrastructure did not replace existing institutions; each set common standards and provided a framework for securely exchanging information. This facilitated a competitive private ecosystem to flourish, advancing financial inclusion at scale and giving rise to one of the world's largest fintech ecosystems. The public sector provides the rails; providers build on them.

The India Energy Stack (IES), an initiative of the Ministry of Power, applies this approach to the power sector for the first time anywhere. IES is a shared set of specifications that enables every power-sector system to exchange data securely and verifiably, without custom integrations, so that the infrastructure already built can deliver its full

value to citizens, utilities, and the economy. The design suits India's federal structure: Electricity is a concurrent subject, and distribution is run by utilities owned or overseen by states. A shared, standardised way such as IES enables national coordination at scale. This can further leverage AI to forecast demand, balance a renewable-heavy grid, coordinate millions of distributed resources, and price power dynamically, helping India both power the AI economy and run a cleaner, cheaper energy system.

Electricity is only part of the picture. The wider task is integration across the energy system, spanning more than a dozen ministries, several electricity regulators, and a range of fuels. The 2006 Integrated Energy Policy made the case for whole-system planning; the digital tools to act on it now exist. As institutional capacity for integrated energy planning is addressed, IES can provide a coordinating mechanism that brings these agencies onto shared intelligence.

Structural reforms in energy strengthen external resilience, lower costs across the economy, prepare the sector for AI, mobilise investment, and provide firm foundations for the next generation of Indian enterprise.

Sharma is chair, India Energy Stack, an initiative of the Ministry of Power. Kumar is head of programme, India Energy Stack and executive director, FSR Global

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The India Energy Stack is a shared set of specifications that enables every power-sector system to exchange data securely and verifiably, so that the infrastructure already built can deliver its full value

• AUTOMOBILES

Ethanol blending in fuel: Why road ahead is bumpy



ANIL SASI

MARUTI SUZUKI’S advertising catchlines of the early 2000s, “*kitna deti hai*” and “*petrol khatam hi nahin hunda*”, were instant hits, distilling the Indian motorist’s fascination with fuel efficiency. Decades earlier, Hero Honda had struck a similar chord with its “fill it, shut it, forget it” campaign, highlighting the efficiency of its four-stroke engines. It also buttressed the notion that thrift at the pump was the ultimate measure of automotive value.

That sentiment has proved resilient even as India’s car market has upshifted to premium offerings. The calculus of mileage and the promise of frugality endure in a nation where mobility is expanding, but growth in disposable incomes remain patchy.

Ahead of schedule

That is where the government’s new ethanol blending programme is running into opposition. Last year, India fully transitioned to 20% ethanol blending in petrol — five years ahead of the original target of 2030. E20 fuel — 80% petrol and 20% ethanol — is now the standard petrol variant available nationwide.

So, essentially, within three years, the average ethanol blending level in petrol doubled from the earlier 10% to 20% (this was originally slated to happen over eight years). For older vehicles and those certified for E10 petrol — 90 parts petrol and 10 parts ethanol — this transition came about rather quickly, without sufficient warnings of the consumer-end pitfalls. The experience left motorists, especially those owning older cars and two-wheelers, feeling somewhat short-changed.

Now, there are three problems with using a higher ethanol blend in petrol for engines not designed for these blends:

First, there is a substantial drop in fuel economy depending on when the car was manufactured.

Second, E20 fuel in internal combustion engine (ICE) vehicles, especially older ones, can damage parts, owing to factors like corrosion, given ethanol’s hygroscopic nature (hygroscopy refers to the property of a substance to attract and hold water molecules from the surrounding environment, either through absorption or adsorption).

Third, vehicle owners in India cur-

• ETHANOL: PHYSICS AND CHEMISTRY

ETHANOL CAN help reduce carbon dioxide emissions because it contains less carbon than petrol. Ethanol’s chemical formula is C₂H₅OH, meaning each molecule contains two carbon atoms. Petrol is made up of hydrocarbons that typically contain 8 to 12 carbon atoms. As the share of ethanol in a fuel blend increases, the amount of carbon dioxide released when the fuel is burned is lower.

HOWEVER, ETHANOL has a lower calorific value than petrol. A litre of ethanol contains substantially less energy than a litre of petrol, resulting in roughly 30% lower mileage.

ETHANOL HAS a very high octane number. Octane number measures a fuel’s resistance to premature combustion due to compression. Ethanol’s Research Octane Number of



Union Minister Hardeep Puri launches a higher ethanol blend in New Delhi. ANI

around 108 allows it to burn more cleanly inside an internal combustion engine than pure petrol.

ETHANOL AND ethanol-based fuels

have been used in sports cars because of their superior anti-knock characteristics, better power potential and cooling effect stemming from their high latent heat of vaporisation.

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> recently do not have an option to choose different fuels at the petrol pump.

Also, regular ICE cars running on higher ethanol blends, alongside the drop in mileage, are harder to start on winter mornings because ethanol burns at a higher temperature than petrol.

While a fuel with 10 per cent ethanol (E10) made little difference to a car’s performance, anything above is said to impact operations. And the worsening of the performance does not exactly progress in a linear fashion as the blending increases.

Material damage

The government deputed The Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI) to study the impact of E20 fuel on the materials used in fuel-system components. An evaluation of eight metals, six elastomers, and four plastics used in various components was carried out through “systematic exercise of laboratory immersion”. The study was conducted with E20 as test fuel and commercial petrol (Bharat Stage IV emission standards) as a baseline fuel (E10) for comparative assessment.

The ARAI study concluded that the impact of E20 on metals tested “was found to be insignificant based on the corrosion rates”, with polychloroprene and fluoro-elastomer found to perform “similar or better in most of the properties with E20”. The impact of E20 on “tensile strength and volume change properties” was found to be

Fuelling protests

Regular ICE cars running on higher ethanol blends, alongside the drop in mileage, are harder to start on winter mornings because ethanol burns at a higher temperature than petrol.

While a fuel with 10 per cent ethanol (E10) made little difference to a car’s performance, anything above that is said to impact operations.

For the Indian motorist, mileage calculus matters most. But higher ethanol blending has other problems, and significant advantages, too

that there are no conclusive studies into the long-term impact blended fuel can have on non-compliant vehicles, but flagged that it could definitely have an impact on the engine’s life, its various rubber parts, valves, and piston heads, among others.

It is the E25 transition that has hassled automakers at the moment, since this will require additional engineering and validation work around engine calibration, fuel-system durability, corrosion resistance, and material compatibility.

Consumer bears the brunt

This is just months after the government wrapped up the E20 transition. In all probability, the cost of vehicles will go up too, and the consumer will have to bear it. Not to mention the lower mileage, which a lot of customers are testifying to after the E10 to E20 shift.

According to sources in the government, the move towards blends higher than E20 is “not being pushed through in a hurry and there will be enough time given for vehicles and oil companies to gear up for this transition”.

Why is the government pushing for blends beyond E20? The main reason is to lower India’s dependence on fuel imports and aid domestic ethanol production.

There’s a political angle too: the agricultural lobby, especially from Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh, is pushing hard for ethanol blends to be hiked since farmers, such as those growing sugarcane, are sitting on significant overcapacity. For the oil marketing companies such as Indian Oil and Bharat Petroleum too, there are challenges, but as they are mostly state-owned, they are unlikely to protest.

Now for adapting the existing set of vehicles to E25, car makers said they would have to run fresh tests to see what impact the higher ethanol blend will have on vehicles on the road. For new vehicles, the manufacturers will have to recalibrate and redo the certification and homologation for emissions, because all the vehicles that are selling now have been tested, certified, and homologated for emissions using E20.

Then, of course, there is the looming question: the impact on mileage. The problem here is that the brunt of the drop in fuel efficiency from the E10 to E20 transition was borne by the motorist. “In case of this new transition too, the consumer will likely end up bearing the brunt of any drop in fuel efficiency. For older vehicles, there is the added question over vehicle damage due to the high ethanol mix. That too is left to the consumer,” a representative of an auto manufacturing association said.

• LAW

Media’s ‘public function’: Impact of Delhi HC verdict on press freedom, privacy

Vineet Bhalla
New Delhi, July 6

FUNDAMENTAL RIGHTS guaranteed by the Indian Constitution have traditionally been viewed as a shield for citizens against the State.

However, a judgment by the Delhi High Court this month extended their “horizontal application”, ruling that private media houses perform a “public function” and can be taken to a High Court for violating an individual’s right to privacy.

A two-judge bench upheld a single-judge’s order directing TV Today Network to pay Rs 5 lakh in compensation for broadcasting details that could identify a minor, who was a victim of sexual assault.

The judgment, authored by Justice C Hari Shankar on behalf of himself and Justice O P Shukla, has implications for press freedom, privacy, and avenues through which citizens can sue the media.

Case of identification

In 2005, a woman filed a police complaint accusing her husband of sexually assaulting their minor daughter. Despite the woman refusing to interact with an Aaj Tak TV crew, the network broadcast a segment that disclosed identifying details like her husband’s name and visuals of their house. The mother then filed a writ petition before the High Court.

The main legal question before the High Court was whether a writ petition could be filed against a private TV channel. Under Article 226 of the Constitution, High Courts have the power to issue writs for the enforcement of fundamental rights or any other legal right against the State or authorities discharging public duties.

‘Public functionary’ role

The court ruled that the media, even when privately owned, discharges a “public function”. Referring to previous Supreme

Court judgements, it reasoned that the media’s role in disseminating news and shaping public opinion is so central to society that it constitutes a public function. Noting that it would be “unrealistic to hold that the media... do not perform any public function,” the court held that this role carries an inherent “public duty to ensure that the rights of the public are not prejudiced or injured by the manner in which such public function is performed.”

Based on this, the court applied the fundamental right to privacy horizontally. While fundamental rights are typically applied vertically, meaning a citizen enforces them against the government, horizontal application allows a citizen to enforce these rights against a non-State actor.

A Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court had, in the 2023 *Kaushal Kishor* judgment, established this principle, ruling that certain fundamental rights can be enforced horizontally against private individuals.

The Delhi High Court has now extended this principle specifically to the right to privacy against the press, holding that the channel’s broadcast, aired without consent, was an illegal intrusion into the victim’s privacy, justifying the award of monetary compensation in a writ court.

Shift from civil courts

Legal experts told *The Indian Express* that this ruling could alter the landscape of media litigation in India.

Senior Advocate Madhavi Goradia Divan noted that while the legal groundwork existed in the *Kaushal Kishor* judgment, its specific use in the context of the media is novel.

Shameek Sen, professor of law at the West Bengal National University of Juridical Sciences, called the ruling a “logical corollary” to *Kaushal Kishor*, but cautioned that the context is vastly different. “That case involved statements made by a sitting

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 minister,” he said. “But the media is typically designed to be an instrument that keeps the State in check. You cannot equate the media with the State.”

Sen added that for any act of journalistic irresponsibility, the ideal remedy should be standard civil remedies like defamation suits or tort claims. “By allowing a writ petition against a private media house, the court is essentially constitutionalising a dispute that should have been settled in the realm of private law,” he said.

The shift towards writ courts is largely driven by delays in India’s civil justice system, according to Divan.

Chilling effect

The primary concern is the potential for weaponisation. Politicians and corporations might use this decision to prevent critical reporting by citing breach of privacy.

Kaushik Moitra, partner at Bharucha & Partners, said: “By declaring all press activ-

ity a ‘public function’, it hands future litigants an easier maintainability argument”. He warned of unintended consequences, including the possibility that “defamation-style claims may be repackaged as privacy/dignity claims”.

Sen said that the precedent could create a chilling effect where “journalists will become more docile and defensive, and editorial controls will become overly stringent out of fear of facing constitutional writs”.

Yet, experts agreed that context will be crucial. The Delhi HC’s strict insistence on consent was rooted in the heightened privacy considerations of a minor sexual assault victim. Divan said that genuine investigative journalism concerning matters of public interest will remain protected, “because public interest will certainly trump the privacy interest.” Moitra said that courts could require a strict public interest analysis to avoid allowing privacy to become “a tool for prior restraint.”

ELECTRIC 3-WHEELERS MAKE UP 61% OF ANNUAL ELECTRICITY DEMAND FROM INDIA’S EV POPULATION

‘Prioritise charging infra for electric 3Ws’

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 6

AS A government-led push to adopt electric vehicles (EVs) gains momentum, a statistics ministry report has said commercial three-wheeler charging corridors should be prioritised as this category of EVs accounts for the majority of electricity demand.

According to the India EV Electricity Demand Assessment Report, part of the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation’s (MoSPI) report of the Expert Committee on Energy Statistics, electric three-wheelers make up as much as 61% of the annual electricity demand from India’s EV population of 8.97 million vehicles.

“Although 2W vehicles dominate fleet population, their electricity demand remains

lower than 3W and HMV (Heavy Motor Vehicles) categories because of lower annual distance and lower per kilometre energy consumption,” the report, released on Monday, said.

As per the report, the annual electricity demand from all the EVs in the country is equal to 20.07 terawatt-hours per year, or roughly 1.1% of India’s annual electricity generation. While this indicates that “current EV penetration remains manageable for the national power grid”, the NITI Aayog estimates that it may rise to 100 TWh-640 TWh/year by 2030.

“The increasing penetration of EVs introduces additional electricity demand on the national grid, making it essential to quantify category-wise energy consumption for future infrastructure planning,” the report said, with the expert com-

● India’s EVs and their electricity requirement

EV segment	Estimated number	Electricity demand (million kWh/year)
2-wheelers	4,365,648	2,095.51
3-wheelers	4,144,490	12,320.68
Light Motor Vehicles/cars	425,562	1,276.60
Medium Motor/goods vehicles	5,271	28.46
Heavy Motor Vehicles/buses/trucks	32,940	4,348.08
TOTAL	8,973,911	20,069.43

SOURCE: REPORT OF THE EXPERT COMMITTEE ON ENERGY STATISTICS, MoSPI

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> mittee recommending that the government’s commitments warrant systematic estimation and dissemination of electricity consumption by EVs in India.

The MoSPI report comes days after the Delhi government said no petrol motorcycles and scooters will be reg-

istered after March 31, 2028, while the registration of new CNG auto-rickshaws will stop in 2026-27. As such, starting April 2028, every new two- and three-wheeler sold in Delhi will have to be electric.

This sweeping policy is a first in India and aims to make



Charging station of electric cars in Gurugram. GAJENDRA YADAV

the country’s capital pollution-free by March 2030.

As per the MoSPI report, there are 4.37 million electric two-wheelers in the country and 4.14 million three-wheelers, together making up 95% of all EVs in India.

Heavy Motor Electric Ve-

hicles or buses and trucks, meanwhile, only make up 0.4% of all EVs but command an electricity share of almost 22%, with the report noting that “annual energy consumption increases significantly with vehicle size... due to higher payload and long-distance operation”.

Apart from commercial three-wheeler charging corridors, the report also said future infrastructure deployment should prioritise urban fleet charging stations, bus depots and freight charging hubs, and fast-charging infrastructure for heavy-duty transportation.

“Residential charging associated with two-wheelers is comparatively manageable because of lower charging power and lower annual electricity consumption,” it added.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Cash transfers helped Odisha, Maharashtra women; review amount periodically: EAC-PM

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 6

CALLING FOR the continuation of the cash transfer scheme for women in Maharashtra and Odisha and a periodic review of the amounts to adjust for inflation and household spending patterns, a paper by a member of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) has found the schemes boosted expenditure by as much as 46% in the case of Maharashtra and 28% for Odisha, with the increase being “qualitatively welfare-improving” as the share of money spent on lifestyle, medical, and educational purposes rose.

“...the policy implications are clear and actionable,” the paper, titled ‘Unconditional Women Cash Transfer Programmes in India: Evidence from Maharashtra and Odisha’ and authored by Soumya Kanti Ghosh and Shagishna K, said.

“Both programmes should be sustained and evolved toward cash-plus architectures that combine the income transfer with voluntary capacity-building, digital literacy, and SHG (self-help group) linkage components... Transfer amounts should be reviewed periodically for adequacy in light of inflation and evolving household expenditure patterns, with efficiency

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● EAC-PM PAPER

● As per the paper, the Maharashtra cash transfer scheme raised month-end balances by 84% and spending by 46%

● In Odisha, balances rose 45% and spending 28%

● The paper called for periodic review of cash transfer amounts in light of inflation

gains from improved targeting deployed to fund enhanced benefits and complementary services for beneficiaries,” the paper further said.

Ghosh is a part-time member of the EAC-PM and SBI’s Group Chief Economic Advisor, while Shagishna K is an economist in SBI’s Economic Research Department. The paper analysed account-level monthly data to evaluate Maharashtra’s Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana and Odisha’s Subhadra Yojana. The former involves the monthly transfer of Rs 1,500 to eligible women, while the Subhadra Yojana scheme offers bi-annual instalments totalling Rs 10,000 per year. As per the results of the analysis by Ghosh and Shagishna, the Maharashtra cash transfer scheme raised month-end balances by 84%, or

Rs 6,884, for each beneficiary and spending by 46% (Rs 1,349). In Odisha, on the other hand, balances rose by 45% (Rs 6,887) and spending by 28% (Rs 1,920). It was found that for every Rs 100 of cash that was transferred, Rs 90 was spent. Older women saved more, while women with lower education showed the urge to spend on education.

“Remarkably, both programmes generate positive household spillover effects, improving financial positions of family members while reducing their expenditure outflows,” the papers said, noting that a 10% rise in the account balances of women in Odisha was associated with a 1.9% decline in their relatives’ spending. Meanwhile, in Maharashtra, it was associated with a 23% jump in relatives’ month-end balances and a 49% fall in their spending.

“Such results are in conformity with global trends that reveal women-focused transfers generate stronger developmental outcomes than gender-neutral transfers, but in India the digital story has revolutionised such payment mechanisms,” the papers said, adding that adoption of UPI accelerated significantly after transfer receipt in Maharashtra, “documenting an important digital financial inclusion dividend”. FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

U.S. PRESIDENT'S THREAT AFTER IRAN PROJECTS DEFIANCE AT KHAMENEI FUNERAL

Either a deal with Iran, or US will 'finish the job': Trump

Tehran bent on retaining control over Hormuz Strait

Reuters

Washington, July 6

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump said on Monday the United States would either reach a deal with Iran or "finish the job," renewing his threat of military action as Tehran projects defiance following the funeral of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

Indirect US-Iran talks ended last week without any public sign of headway toward a lasting peace, despite a 60-day ceasefire intended to create space for diplomacy following US and Israeli strikes that triggered the conflict. "We're either going to make a deal or we're going to finish the job. OK. And it won't be tough to finish the job. I'd rather make a deal, because I don't want to affect 91 million people," Trump told reporters in the Oval Office.

"We can knock down their bridges in one hour, we can knock out their energy



A truck carrying coffins of the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and members of his family make way through mourners during the funeral procession in Tehran on Monday. AP

supply.... They don't have any money now. We haven't given them any money."

Trump spoke after Khamenei's weekend funeral where, rather than looking weakened by the war that began with US and Israeli strikes on February 28, Iranians appeared to be defiant, united and determined to shape what comes next.

The 60-day clock towards a final deal following the ceasefire agreement and the accompanying MoU is yet to start. In that vacuum, Iran is setting the pace,

including in the Strait.

Although huge revenues might be earned from charging fees for vessels using the strait, Tehran sees Hormuz less as an economic asset than as a source of political legitimacy, said Alex Vatanka of US-based Middle East Institute.

"The symbolic part is more important for the Iranians than revenues," Vatanka said. "They want some kind of symbolic acceptance the Strait is Iran's. It's about accepting Iran as the sovereign power over the Strait."

Mourners call for vengeance on Trump during funeral procession

Tehran: Crowds of Iranians marched through the streets of Tehran on Monday in a funeral procession for slain leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the biggest day yet in a week of massive memorial ceremonies demonstrating the grip of surviving clerical leaders.

The caskets of the slain leader and four of his family members were driven in a large truck through the streets, while fire hoses sprayed water from above to keep the marchers cool.

As they passed under a bridge, mourners hurled stones at a billboard hung from above showing US President Donald Trump with a bullet aimed at his head. "The US killed our father," it read. "We won't let you go!"

As demonstrators set fire to US and British flags, women in black chadors held aloft red placards with "KILL TRUMP" in black letters.

REUTERS



Cuba's Bengal Cubs

The birth of four Bengal tiger cubs, including this exceedingly rare white tiger, at the Cuban National Zoo in Havana is being seen as a small miracle on an island stifled by shortages of fuel, medicine and power outages. "It's only the second time" white tigers have been born in Cuba, a zoo-keeper said, gleaming with pride. REUTERS

China test fires missile into Pacific from nuclear sub, region alarmed

Beijing: China's military test-fired a missile from a nuclear-powered submarine into the Pacific on Monday, state media reported, drawing criticism and concerns from Japan, Australia and New Zealand over Beijing's expanding military reach.

A nuclear submarine of the People's Liberation Army Navy launched the missile carrying a dummy warhead toward inter-

national waters in the Pacific at 12:01 pm, the official Xinhua news agency said. The missile landed in "designated waters," it added, without giving further details of the location.

Xinhua described the launch as a "routine arrangement" of China's annual military training and said it was not directed against any specific country or target. REUTERS

NATO defence push strains Europe's budgets

Reuters

London, July 6

NATO SECRETARY General Mark Rutte will insist at this week's alliance summit that member states are keeping their promise to boost defence spending. Yet progress has been uneven and push is already stretching some national budgets.

Under pressure from President Donald Trump, members of the 32-country military pact agreed at last year's summit to boost defence spending to 5% of GDP by 2035 - just over double the overall level for European states and Canada in 2025.

But since then, two camps

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have emerged: one is led by Germany and the mostly Nordic and eastern European nations which have found the fiscal space to raise spending; in the other are several big players struggling to do the same.

"The UK isn't managing, for example. France isn't and Italy isn't either," Guntram Wolff, senior fellow at the Bruegel economics think tank, said of the three largest economies in Europe behind Germany.

NATO says its European members plus Canada spent an extra \$90 billion on defence in real terms last year compared to 2024 as they seek to raise core military spending to 3.5% of GDP by 2035 with a further 1.5% GDP on security-related items.

NATO SUMMIT STARTS TODAY

WHICH LEADERS WILL BE THERE?: Leaders from NATO's 32 member countries, including Trump. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, South Korean President Lee Jae Myung will join the dinner on Tuesday evening.

WHAT WILL LEADERS DISCUSS?: Progress towards defence spending targets, boosting defence industrial production and how to implement "burden-shifting" from the US to Europe.

WHAT WILL THE ALLIANCE DO ON INDUSTRY?: To focus on scaling up weapons production and boosting defence innovation. Will also host a defence industry



A Turkish flag & NATO banner cover buildings ahead of the summit in Ankara. AP

forum in Ankara.

WILL IRAN COME UP?: Members are concerned that the Iran war, and Trump's irritation with Europe over its response to it, could overshadow the summit.

GUTERRES WARNED ABOUT THE CONCENTRATION OF MOST ADVANCED A.I. SYSTEMS WITHIN A HANDFUL OF COMPANIES & COUNTRIES, MEANING DEVELOPING COUNTRIES HAVE LITTLE SAY IN THE PROGRESS OF A.I.

UN's Guterres warns AI outpacing oversight, urges global rules to protect children

Reuters

Geneva, July 6

UN SECRETARY-General Antonio Guterres on Monday warned that artificial intelligence is developing faster than anyone can keep up, calling for globally harmonised rules to reduce potential risks - especially to children.

"A technology that can reshape economies, transform the world of work, sway elections and tilt the balance of security is being deployed faster than anyone, including the people building it, can keep up," Guterres told delegates at the first-ever government-level global dialogue on AI in Geneva.

"Innovation needs guardrails... If AI is to be powerful, it must be governed," Guterres told delegates.

The two-day inaugural UN Global Dialogue on AI Governance is not intended to forge a treaty, but to discuss how to set rules to mitigate the potential harms of AI and take advantage of its opportunities.

Delegates will consider a report by a UN-backed independent scientific panel of 40 experts, who will present findings from the first global, independent scientific assessment of AI.

A more comprehensive report is planned next year, alongside a second global meet-

ing in New York.

Guterres stressed that globally harmonised rules on AI must prioritise safety for children after examples of minors being steered towards self-harm and being deceived by machines posing as friends.

"We do not let medicine reach a child until it is proven safe. We test every toy. Yet AI has reached our children - their learning, their friendships, their most private questions - before anyone asked what it would do to them," he said.

He also called for an AI Child Safety Pledge, where companies building systems would have to prove they are safe before making them ac-



UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres during a meeting at the UN headquarters in New York City on April 27. FILE

cessible to children.

Systems should also not be allowed to generate sexual

images of children, and when a child shows signs of distress, the system should stop and

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> connect them to a human for help. While AI poses significant opportunities, such as in healthcare, Guterres said the world's institutions were not prepared for machines that make decisions, and that AI's breakneck speed of development meant machines were increasingly making choices with little human or government oversight. "The internet took 15 years to reach a billion people. AI got there in two," Guterres told delegates.

He also warned about the concentration of the most advanced AI systems within a handful of companies and countries, meaning developing countries have little say in the

progress of AI and risk being left behind.

The independent report of scientific experts found that AI development is even more concentrated, with the US accounting for 75% of the computing power among the world's top 500 AI supercomputers, and China 15%.

While globally over a billion people now use conversational AI weekly, adoption in developing countries lags, the report added. Guterres said if used well, AI could compress decades of development into years, potentially becoming "the great equalizer of the 21st century".

The head of Libya's Presi-

dential Council, Mohamed al-Menfi, urged that the AI gap be closed in Africa, which accounts for 10% of the world's population but only possesses fewer than 2% of global data centres.

"AI cannot be a legitimate resource if African countries cannot make use of it," he said, calling for participation of African states in design of AI rules.

Georgian President Mikheil Kavelashvili told delegates that world leaders also had a shared responsibility to create robust international laws to prevent the power of AI from becoming an "instrument of totalitarian control and new digital tyranny".

